Little Tadpole’s Journey (Portfolio Piece)

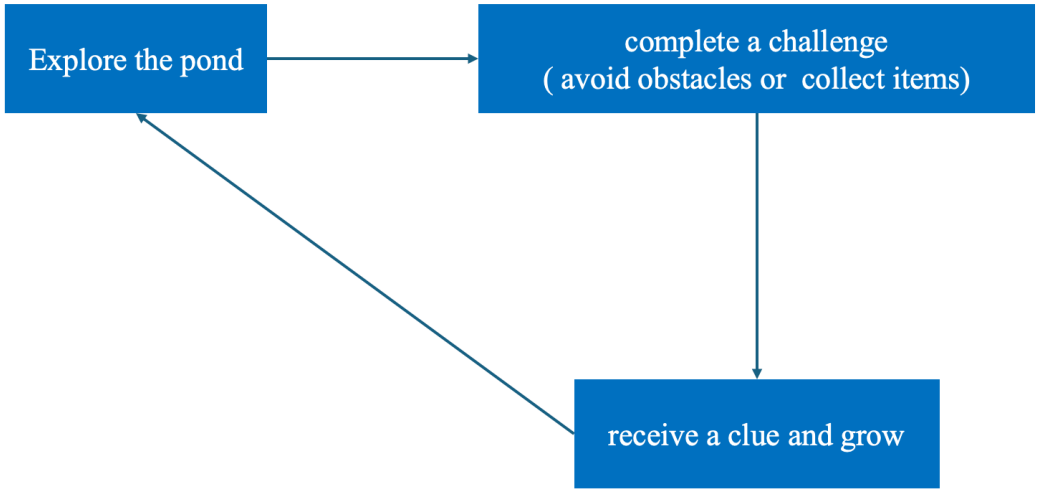
Game Overview

Little Tadpole's Journey is a 2D adventure and puzzle game inspired by the classic Chinese children's story Little Tadpoles Look for Their Mother. Players control a young tadpole using the mouse and explore a pond across five levels, each featuring different challenges, such as avoiding obstacles, collecting food, and escaping predators. As the tadpole progresses, it gradually grows legs and unlocks new abilities, including dashing, climbing, and jumping. The game combines exploration, environmental puzzles, and the biological process of frog metamorphosis.

Design Pillars

Transformation; Exploration; Learning

Core Loop



Story Synopsis

The story is derived from a classic Chinese story (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7fV7EER3mdY):

A young tadpole awakens in a pond and sets out to find its mother. Grandpa Shrimp gives the first clue: she has big eyes. The tadpole next helps a goldfish collect food and learns that its mother has a white belly. During the journey, it begins to grow hind legs and discovers it can move faster. The tadpole then encounters a crab whose claws block the route. After escaping, it learns that its mother has four legs. As its front legs grow, it gains the ability to climb onto lily pads. A dangerous catfish patrols the next region, forcing the tadpole to hide and choose safe routes. The tadpole grows stronger and learns to jump. In the final pond, the tadpole combines its new abilities to reach a frog. The clues finally match: big eyes, a pale belly, and four legs. It recognizes its mother, reunites with her, and completes its transformation into a young frog.

Five-Level Plan

Level 1 — Grandpa Shrimp (Tutorial)

Learn click-to-move navigation. Avoid stones and water plants to reach Grandpa Shrimp. Clue: Mother has big eyes.

Level 2 — The Goldfish's Request

Collect enough food for the goldfish while avoiding obstacles. Clue: Mother has a white belly. Growth: Hind legs; unlock Dash.

Level 3 — The Crab's Claws

Time a dash through opening and closing crab claws. Clue: Mother has four legs. Growth: Front legs; unlock Climb.

Level 4 — The Catfish's Territory

Avoid a patrolling catfish by moving between safe areas and climbing onto lily pads. Growth: Tail shortens; unlock Jump.

Level 5 — Finding Mother

Combine swimming, Dash, Climb, and Jump to cross the final area. Use accumulated

clues to recognize the frog mother. The tadpole becomes a young frog.

MVP Requirements

- Mouse-controlled tadpole movement.
- Two playable levels with different challenges.
- Basic obstacles and collision detection.
- Food collection and NPC interactions.
- Tadpole growth and a dash ability.
- Basic UI, including a start screen and level completion screen.